HERCULES

Hercules

SIZE RANKING 5

BRIGHTEST STAR
Kornephoros (β) 2.8

GENITIVE Herculis

ABBREVIATION Her

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
June–July

FULLY VISIBLE
90°N–38°S

This large but not particularly prominent constellation of the northern sky represents Hercules, the strong man of Greek myth. In the sky, Hercules is depicted clothed in a lion's pelt, brandishing a club and the severed head of the watchdog Cerberus and kneeling with one foot on the head of the celestial dragon, Draco—the tools and conquests of some of his 12 labors.

The most distinctive feature of this constellation is a quadrilateral of stars called the Keystone, which is composed of Epsilon (ε), Zeta (ζ), Eta (η), and Pi (π) Herculis.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

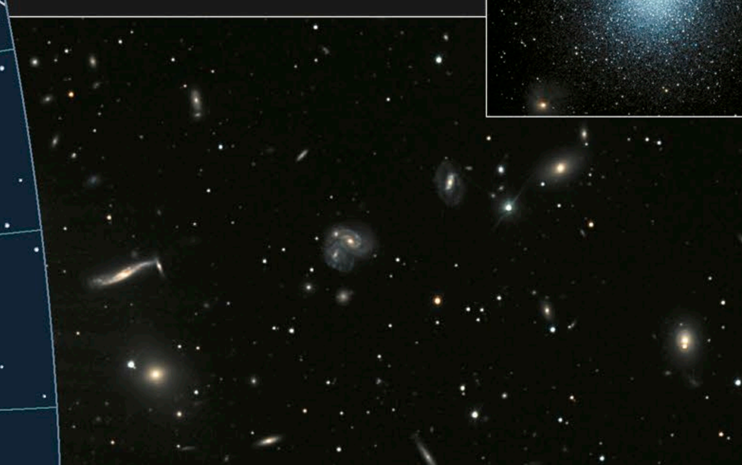
Alpha (α) Herculis, (see p.285), or Rasalgethi, is actually the second-brightest star in Hercules. It fluctuates between 3rd and 4th magnitudes. As with most such erratic variables, Rasalgethi is a bloated red giant that pulsates in size, causing the brightness changes. A small telescope brings a 5th-magnitude blue-green companion star into view.

On one side of the Keystone lies M13, which is regarded as the finest globular cluster of northern skies. Under ideal conditions, M13 can be glimpsed with the naked eye, and through binoculars it appears like a hazy star half the width of a full moon. Slightly farther away from the Keystone is a second globular cluster—M92. This often overlooked cluster is smaller and fainter than M13, and when seen through binoculars, it can easily be mistaken for an ordinary star.

Several readily seen double stars are to be found in Hercules, including Kappa (κ) Herculis, with components of 5th and 6th magnitudes, and 100 Herculis, with its two 6th-magnitude stars. Positioned closer together, and hence requiring higher magnification, are 95 Herculis, with two 5th-magnitude components, and Rho (ρ) Herculis, with components of 5th and 6th magnitudes.

UPSIDE DOWN
In the night sky, Hercules is positioned with his feet pointing toward the pole (top left in this picture) and his head pointing south.

GLOBULAR CLUSTER M13
Through binoculars, this cluster appears as a rounded patch of light. It breaks up into countless starry points when viewed through a small telescope.



THE HERCULES GALAXY CLUSTER
Every fuzzy object in this picture is a faint galaxy in the cluster Abell 2151, some 500 million light-years away.